



Staunch ally: Mohammed Shami faced widespread abuse on social media after India's 10-wicket loss to Pakistan in the 2021 T20 World Cup, but his captain Virat Kohli didn't just stand by him — he stood up for him. AFP

England's master of movement — not with swagger, but with patience. It was a masterclass in defensive batting. He assumed the stature of greatness on that tour.

And if that England tour revealed his resolve, Australia revealed his appetite. The seven Test centuries he hit in Australia confirmed his greed to excel. He studied the conditions, understood when to leave, when to strike, and always, when to fight.

Virat's work ethic was the most infectious trait that galvanised the team into world cricket's most performing and fit bunch. He was a terror for the opposition but a friend and guide for his teammates. I have seen players from the opposition

approach him for guidance, and Virat was always eager to help. I have seen him part with some excellent bats because he was not an insecure competitor.

It was common to see Virat go through his fitness drills without being prompted, taking 40 to 50 catches and practising run-outs from different positions and angles. His drive for perfection was nothing short of madness. I remember this Test at Cape Town in 2018. India lost the Test, but Virat's show of tenacity left us all stunned. He hit a first-innings century (153) in the next match at Centurion that took the wind out of the South African bowlers.

To prepare for the second Test, he hit the nets with bowlers who were instructed to bounce the ball from 18 yards. He didn't flinch. He chose to meet fire with fire, and that's when my admiration for him deepened. He was the ultimate team man — selfless, relentless, unbreakable. He

didn't just lead the team; he became its heartbeat. And when the fight got tough, you could bet he'd be the last man standing.

Virat was a captain forged in fire: relentless in pursuit, unwavering in intent. Every waking hour was bent toward one goal: to make India the best in the world. And he did. Under his leadership, India climbed to the top of the Test rankings, and more importantly, began conquering the final frontier — winning overseas.

What set him apart wasn't just his numbers, but his grit — a refusal to back down, especially against the best in the business. I can never forget his verbal exchange in 2014 with Mitchell Johnson in Melbourne. He kept needling the Aussie during the lunch break. Both stared at each other, but I could see that Virat's ferocity gave the Australian a strong message. A fight was on. It surely was. Virat hammered a sensational century (169) to win his battle with the bowlers in a draw that saw India